

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

ISSUE	ATB-2026-23
COVERAGE PERIOD	9–15 AUG 2026
PUBLICATION DATE	2026-08-15
DOMINANT JUDGMENT	HORMUZ IS NOW A TEXAS RISK DRIVER

Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

Executive Warning: The U.S.-Iran war has moved from a background risk to an active driver of Texas energy exposure: Iran has struck at least three tankers in the Strait of Hormuz this week alone, including two UAE state-owned vessels on 13–14 August, with shipping traffic running well below normal under an active U.S. naval blockade. Separately, Fort Worth’s JPS Health Network — Tarrant County’s safety-net hospital system — remains in its second week of network downtime after detecting suspicious activity on 3 August; cause is still unconfirmed, but the continuity impact is not. North Korea’s recruitment-based targeting of defense and aerospace personnel has escalated to federally confirmed active exploitation, sustaining pressure on Texas’s DIB and aerospace base. A new White House framework, run through DOJ and DHS, now authorizes vetted private-sector participation in federal cyber operations against transnational criminal groups. The decision risk this week is treating Hormuz as a distant geopolitical story: it is already repricing energy markets and shipping risk that Texas producers, refiners, and logistics firms carry directly.

Board Implications This Week — Ask

What specific Hormuz trigger — a price move, an insurance repricing, a further attack pattern — changes our procurement, hedging, shipping, or customer-communication posture?

Board Implications This Week — Direct

Require validation of how long essential services can run with core systems degraded, using JPS Health Network’s eight-plus-day timeline as a real-world benchmark rather than a hypothetical.

Board Implications This Week — Document

Confirm in writing that the DOJ/DHS approval path for federal cyber-operation cooperation requests exists before one arrives, not after.

Board Implications This Week — Rehearse

Brief DIB, aerospace, and software personnel on recruitment-channel targeting risk — the access path now runs through legitimate employees’ external job-seeking activity, not just HR intake.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

Liberty CTI assesses with **High confidence** that the Strait of Hormuz has become a sustained, not episodic, driver of energy-price and maritime-insurance volatility, and that Texas — while structurally insulated as a major producer — is directly exposed through global pricing, marine insurance, imported feedstocks, and customer-market disruption.

Three separate tanker incidents this week (14 and 15 August, following earlier disruption reported 9–11 August) confirm a pattern of repeated, not isolated, attacks. The known fact is the attacks and the resulting shipping disruption — UKMTO and wire reporting corroborate multiple incidents; UAE attribution to Iran is a stated government position, not independent Liberty CTI attribution. The assessment is durability: Liberty CTI judges this is more likely a sustained condition than a short-lived spike, given the active U.S. blockade, stalled ceasefire talks, and Iran's demonstrated willingness to strike repeatedly.

Bottom line: Texas producers may see upside from higher prices; refiners, petrochemical firms, logistics operators, and consumer-facing businesses face higher costs and volatility regardless. This is now a live hedging and continuity question, not a background geopolitical watch item.

Section I

What Changed This Week

Repeated Tanker Attacks Confirm Hormuz Is a Sustained Condition

Iran struck **at least three vessels in the Strait of Hormuz this week**, including two ADNOC-operated (UAE state-owned) tankers hit by drones on 13–14 August, with a further incident reported 15 August. UKMTO advisories confirm commercial shipping traffic remains well below normal under the active U.S. naval blockade of Iran. No casualties were reported. The decision problem is not whether any single Texas asset was struck — none was — it is whether leadership has a pre-defined threshold for when this volatility changes hedging, sourcing, or shipping posture.

JPS Health Network Enters Its Second Week of Network Downtime

Fort Worth's **JPS Health Network** — a 582-bed hospital and 25-plus community clinics serving Tarrant County — has operated under manual downtime procedures since detecting suspicious activity in its technology environment on 3 August. As of this week, the outage has persisted beyond a week, with patients filing paper intake forms and facing medication-refill delays. JPS has not confirmed a cybersecurity cause; Liberty CTI does not attribute the outage to malicious activity absent that confirmation. The executive lesson stands regardless of cause: prolonged digital degradation creates patient-care and legal decisions well before attribution is resolved.

DPRK Recruitment Campaign Reaches Federally Confirmed Status

North Korea's Lazarus Group has escalated its recruitment-based targeting of defense and aerospace personnel to **federally confirmed active exploitation** — this week's development moves the campaign from single-vendor reporting to confirmation by Microsoft and inclusion in the federal Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog, with a federal patch deadline set for 25 August. Confirmed targeting spans defense, aerospace, and related technical personnel. Texas's aerospace and cloud/AI talent concentration keeps this a live exposure for the state's DIB and software-engineering base.

White House Authorizes Private-Sector Participation in Federal Cyber Operations

On **12 August**, the White House signed a National Security Presidential Memorandum directing the Homeland Security Task Force's National Coordination Center — run by two Executive Directors from DOJ and DHS — to establish a program allowing vetted private companies to participate in specifically authorized federal cyber operations against transnational criminal organizations. Participating companies enter contractual agreements directly with DOJ or DHS. This is a governance and legal-authority change, not a new adversary threat; it directly affects any organization that could plausibly receive a federal cooperation request.

Section II

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses that attacks on UAE-operated tankers in the Strait of Hormuz materially increase near-term energy-price, shipping, insurance, and supply-chain volatility. Texas is partially insulated as a major oil, gas, refining, petrochemical, and LNG producer, but Texas firms remain exposed to global pricing, tanker availability, marine insurance, imported feedstocks, and customer-market disruption.

HIGH CONFIDENCE

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: UKMTO/JMIC maritime advisories; multi-source wire reporting on the 13–15 August tanker incidents; U.S. naval blockade status. Primary uncertainty: this is a durability judgment, not an attribution judgment — UAE attribution to Iran is a stated government position, not independently confirmed by Liberty CTI.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Energy, refining, petrochemical, and logistics leadership should define the specific Hormuz trigger — price, insurance, or attack-pattern — that changes procurement and hedging posture, rather than waiting for a Texas-direct incident.

KJ-2

Liberty CTI assesses that the JPS Health Network outage is an executive-relevant Texas critical-infrastructure disruption. JPS publicly confirms a network outage and directs patients to alternative communication channels. Cyber causation remains unconfirmed in primary-source reporting; Liberty CTI therefore does not attribute the outage to malicious activity. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: JPS public statements and regional press reporting (Fort Worth Report, NBC 5 DFW, WFAA) corroborated across multiple outlets since 3 August. Primary uncertainty: cause is unconfirmed; JPS has stated only that it detected suspicious activity and initiated downtime procedures.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas hospital and health-system boards should validate how long essential services can function with EHR, identity, scheduling, and pharmacy systems degraded — JPS's timeline is now a real-world benchmark, not a hypothetical.

KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses that North Korea is **very likely** increasing the sophistication of access operations against defense, aerospace, and software targets, now corroborated by federal confirmation rather than single-vendor reporting alone. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: primary vendor threat research on the current Operation Dream Job wave; Microsoft's own confirmation of active exploitation; CISA's addition of the underlying flaw to its Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog with a 25 August federal remediation deadline. Primary uncertainty: full victim scope and any Texas-specific targeting remain unconfirmed in open reporting.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: DIB, aerospace, and software-engineering leadership should brief technical personnel on recruitment-channel targeting risk and confirm patch-management cadence is current as standing practice, not a one-time check.

KJ-4

Liberty CTI assesses that the new White House transnational-crime cyber framework will likely increase government-private sector operational interaction during major cyber investigations and disruption campaigns. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: White House National Security Presidential Memorandum and accompanying fact sheet, 12 August 2026. Primary uncertainty: how broadly the program will be implemented, and whether adversarial states will distinguish participating firms from U.S. government operators.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: CEOs and General Counsel should confirm, in writing, who can approve cooperation with a DOJ/DHS-run federal cyber-operation request before one arrives — no technical team should have standing authority to agree independently.

Section III

Geopolitical Driver

The strategic backdrop is the active U.S.-Iran war, ongoing since 28 February 2026, which has moved from a distant conflict to a direct driver of global energy-market volatility through repeated Hormuz tanker attacks. Layered onto that is DPRK sanctions-evasion and revenue-generation activity via recruitment-based intrusion, and a structural U.S. policy shift toward deeper government-private sector integration in cyber operations. Russia remains a standing watch item: Liberty CTI's baseline holds that Russia has demonstrated both the access (GRU-linked router and telecom compromise, April 2026) and the destructive intent (the Poland energy-sector wiper campaign, December 2025) this pattern would require, and Russia may open its 2026–27 winter energy-strike campaign against Ukraine early, around Ukraine's 24 August Independence Day. No new indicator this week ties that baseline directly to Texas.

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Continuum assessment: Texas remains in **competition, crisis-conditioned by external conflict**. The Iran war is Conflict-phase for the region and now a direct Texas business-risk driver through energy and maritime channels, even without any confirmed Texas-direct incident. **No Flash Warning threshold was met this week.**

Section IV

Why This Matters to Texas

No Texas energy asset has been struck, and no Texas healthcare system beyond JPS has reported comparable disruption. That is not the same as Texas being unexposed. Hormuz volatility reaches every Texas refiner, petrochemical operator, and logistics firm through pricing and insurance regardless of where

the attacks occur. JPS demonstrates that a prolonged outage can degrade a major Texas public-health system for over a week before any cause is confirmed — a timeline every Texas hospital board should treat as plausible for its own operations, not exceptional.

Cross-Sector Cascade Assessment

Energy Hormuz / Refining / LNG	What changed: Hormuz is now the primary external cascade driver for Texas energy. Repeated tanker attacks move crude and LNG prices, marine insurance, and freight rates in ways that affect refinery economics and customer demand even without any direct Texas incident. Why it matters locally: Texas producers may see upside from higher prices; refiners, petrochemical firms, and logistics operators face higher costs and volatility regardless. Cascade risk: Price and insurance volatility reaches trade financing, customer contracts, and capital planning within days.
Financial Trade Financing / Counterparty Risk	What changed: Exposure is largely second-order — trade financing, marine insurance, and counterparty risk tied to energy-market volatility will move faster than any cyber telemetry would. Why it matters locally: The new federal transnational-crime cyber framework creates a direct governance question for banks and payment processors specifically, since they are among the institutions most likely to receive a cooperation request. Cascade risk: Few institutions currently have a documented approval chain for either exposure.
Healthcare / DIB Continuity / Recruitment Risk	Healthcare: JPS Health Network is the strongest Texas-specific case this week — over a week of manual downtime procedures demonstrating that prolonged digital degradation creates patient-care and legal decisions well before attribution is confirmed. DIB: North Korea's recruitment-based targeting of defense and aerospace personnel is now federally confirmed, not just vendor-flagged — sustained pressure on Texas's aerospace, DIB, and software-engineering talent base. Cascade risk: Healthcare degradation creates immediate safety pressure; DIB degradation creates IP-loss and contract-performance pressure.

Section V

Indicators & Warnings — PIR Watch, 1 to 4 Weeks

PIR 3 / I&W 1 Additional tanker attacks or a shift in Iran's targeting pattern [**↑ Rising**]

- Watch for further Strait of Hormuz incidents, or a shift toward U.S.-flagged or Texas-linked cargo specifically.
- Would confirm the Dominant Judgment's durability assessment and raise urgency on the hedging-trigger decision.
- Tied to: PIR 3, escalation indicators.

PIR 6 / I&W 2 Movement in stalled U.S.-Iran ceasefire talks [**→ Sustained**]

- Watch for any credible de-escalation signal in ceasefire negotiations.

- Would be the clearest signal the Dominant Judgment should soften from High to Moderate confidence.
- Tied to: PIR 6, executive decision-relevant warning.

PIR 5 / I&W 3 JPS attribution outcome, or a second Texas healthcare outage [→ *Sustained*]

- Watch for JPS, law enforcement, or a regulator confirming or ruling out a cybersecurity cause, or another Texas health system reporting a comparable prolonged outage.
- Would confirm whether this is an isolated case or an emerging Texas healthcare-sector pattern.
- Tied to: PIR 5, strategic vulnerability exposure across critical infrastructure.

PIR 1 / I&W 4 U.S. government attribution or additional confirmed DPRK victims [↑ *Rising*]

- Watch for formal U.S. government (not just vendor) attribution on the DPRK recruitment campaign, or additional confirmed defense-sector victims.
- Would move this from a federally-confirmed exploitation event to a formally attributed nation-state campaign.
- Tied to: PIR 1, nation-state targeting of Texas critical infrastructure.

PIR 7 / I&W 5 Russian strikes on Ukrainian energy infrastructure around 24 August [→ *Sustained*]

- Watch for Russian strikes timed to Ukraine's 24 August Independence Day, a possible early opening of the 2026–27 winter strike campaign.
- Would raise, not lower, the probability and urgency of Russian cyber retaliation against Western energy and logistics targets — consistent with, not itself confirming, Liberty CTI's standing baseline.
- Tied to: PIR 7, geopolitical-cyber acceleration.

Section VI

Governance Implication Block

Decision at risk	Whether leadership has a pre-defined trigger for when Hormuz-driven volatility changes procurement, hedging, shipping, or customer-communication posture — and, separately, whether critical operations can be validated to run on manual procedures for the length JPS has now demonstrated is realistic.
Owner	CEO, COO, CFO, CISO, General Counsel, continuity leadership. For federal cyber-operation cooperation specifically: the program runs through DOJ and DHS via the National Coordination Center — know that before a request arrives, not after.
Consequence of delay	Being forced to make hedging, sourcing, or continuity decisions live under market pressure instead of against a pre-agreed threshold; discovering during an actual outage that manual-procedure duration assumptions were wrong; unauthorized or legally unprotected cooperation with a federal operational request.
Action this week	Define the specific Hormuz trigger — price move, insurance repricing, further attack pattern — that changes your posture. For any high-dependency operation, validate how long essential services can run with core systems degraded, using JPS's timeline as a real-world benchmark. Confirm the DOJ/DHS approval path for federal cyber-operation cooperation requests exists in writing. Brief DIB/aerospace/software personnel on recruitment-channel targeting risk.

Record to preserve	Hedging and procurement decisions tied to Hormuz triggers; continuity-validation results; any government cooperation request plus counsel review and scope authorization; recruiter-contact records for DIB personnel.
---------------------------	--

From Warning to Decision

Test what this means for your organization.

Reading the warning is one thing. Knowing whether your leadership would recognize it, decide in time, and document the call is another. Liberty CTI starts by establishing your decision environment, then tests it under pressure.

EXECUTIVE INTELLIGENCE BASELINE + EXECUTIVE DECISION EXERCISE →

Section VII

Actions This Week

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

- Ask:** What Hormuz trigger — price, insurance, or attack pattern — changes our posture, and have we defined it in advance?
- Approve:** A continuity validation exercise benchmarked against JPS's actual timeline, not a hypothetical outage duration.
- Document:** The named approval authority for federal cyber-operation cooperation requests under the DOJ/DHS-run program, confirmed in writing this week.
- Rehearse:** A DIB/aerospace recruitment-channel scenario — a convincing external job offer directed at a technical employee, with no advance warning.

Section VIII

Prior Judgment Tracker

Prior judgment	ATB-2026-22 assessed the water-sector OT campaign's occurrence at High confidence — confirmed operational effects across Michigan and New Jersey — with Iranian affiliation carried as the leading hypothesis at Moderate confidence, explicitly unconfirmed.
Current status	Unchanged this issue. No Texas-named victim and no formal U.S. government attribution emerged this week. The active U.S.-Iran war raises the consequence if attribution firms up, but does not itself move confidence on the water-campaign judgment.
What changed	This week's dominant movement was not the water-sector campaign. It was the Strait of Hormuz escalating to repeated, confirmed tanker attacks, and JPS Health Network's continuity crisis becoming the strongest current Texas-specific case.

Confidence movement	New Dominant Judgment established this issue (Hormuz durability) at High confidence. DPRK judgment moved from Moderate to High confidence following federal (not just vendor) corroboration.
Next indicator	A Texas-named victim in the water-sector campaign, formal U.S. attribution, a Hormuz de-escalation signal, or JPS attribution confirmation would each move posture in this thread going forward.

Section IX — Sourcing

Open Source Basis

PRIMARY SOURCES — ATB-2026-23 — COVERAGE WEEK 9–15 AUG 2026 AND CONTINUING BASELINE

GOVERNMENT / MARITIME AUTHORITY

UKMTO / JMIC — Advisory Note, Strait of Hormuz

[ukmto.org – JMIC Advisory Note, Update 082](#)

Published within coverage week. Basis for occurrence confirmation on sustained Hormuz shipping disruption and blockade enforcement status.

PRESS / WIRE

Associated Press — ADNOC Tanker Attacks, 14–15 August 2026

[apnews.com – UAE tankers attacked in Strait of Hormuz](#)

Tier 2 wire reporting; corroborated by follow-on 15 August reporting. UAE attribution to Iran presented as an official claim, not independent Liberty CTI attribution.

ORGANIZATION DISCLOSURE

JPS Health Network — Public Statements on Network Outage

[ipshealthnet.org](#)

Tier 1 primary organization disclosure, corroborated by Fort Worth Report, NBC 5 DFW, and WFAA regional reporting since 3 August. Confirms outage and downtime procedures; does not confirm cyber cause.

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

CISA — Known Exploited Vulnerabilities Catalog

[cisa.gov/known-exploited-vulnerabilities-catalog](#)

Addition confirmed 11 August 2026 with a 25 August federal remediation deadline. Basis for elevating the DPRK recruitment-campaign judgment from vendor-only to federally confirmed.

GOVERNMENT / EXECUTIVE ACTION

The White House — Fact Sheet: Expanding Capabilities to Combat Transnational Cyber-Enabled Crime

[whitehouse.gov – NSPM fact sheet, 12 August 2026](#)

Primary source. Controlling document for scope and authority of the new DOJ/DHS-run private-sector cyber-operations framework.

PRIMARY VENDOR RESEARCH

Check Point Research — Operation Dream Job Campaign Update

[research.checkpoint.com – Shattering the Dream](#)

Published within coverage week. Cited for campaign TTP and targeting detail only; technical exploit detail reserved for a Technical Annex, not this executive brief.

ANALYSIS / OSINT

Critical Threats (ISW) — Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, 8 August 2026criticalthreats.org — 8 August assessment

Cited for the 24 August Ukraine Independence Day timing indicator only; not used to move PIR 7 independently, per Liberty CTI's standing Russia baseline.

PRESS / REGIONAL

Fort Worth Report — JPS Fifth-Day Outage Coveragefortworthreport.org, 7 August 2026

Corroborating regional reporting on JPS outage timeline and "suspicious activity" disclosure. Cited for continuity-impact detail only.

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

WHAT: The Strait of Hormuz saw at least three tanker attacks this week, confirming sustained rather than episodic disruption; Fort Worth's JPS Health Network entered its second week of network downtime with cause still unconfirmed; North Korea's recruitment-based defense-sector targeting reached federally confirmed status; and the White House authorized a new DOJ/DHS-run framework for private-sector participation in federal cyber operations. **WHO:** UKMTO, wire reporting, and UAE officials defined the current-week Hormuz evidence base; JPS's own statements and regional press defined the healthcare case; Check Point Research and federal confirmation defined the DPRK case; the White House defined the governance framework. **WHY:** The active U.S.-Iran war gives Iran continued incentive to pressure global shipping through the Strait; North Korea continues sanctions-evasion and revenue generation through recruitment-based access; the federal government is formalizing private-sector cyber-operations cooperation ahead of an anticipated increase in transnational cybercrime enforcement activity. **WHAT NEXT:** Leadership should not wait for a Texas-direct incident before acting on any of these threads. The immediate task is defining hedging triggers, validating continuity assumptions against JPS's real timeline, and confirming federal cooperation approval authority in writing. *Warnings that arrive too late are not warnings. They are after-action reports.*

For tailored executive briefings or advisory retainer inquiries: intel@libertycti.com · libertycti.com

© 2026 Liberty CTI LLC. All rights reserved. The Alamo Threat Brief and its original analysis may not be reproduced or redistributed without permission.

Liberty CTI assessments reflect analytical judgments based on information available at the time of publication. Forecasts and warning judgments involve uncertainty and may change as new information becomes available. The Alamo Threat Brief provides intelligence decision support and does not constitute legal, financial, investment, or technical cybersecurity advice. See [Terms of Use](#).

Third-party reporting cited in this brief remains the property of its respective owners; citation does not constitute endorsement. Liberty CTI's original analytical judgments remain Liberty CTI intellectual property.

Test what this means for your organization.

EXECUTIVE INTELLIGENCE BASELINE + EXECUTIVE DECISION EXERCISE →

© 2026 Liberty CTI LLC. All rights reserved. The Alamo Threat Brief and its original analysis may not be reproduced or redistributed without permission. Alamo Threat Brief™ is a trademark of Liberty CTI LLC. This document is an archival companion to the published web issue and preserves the assessment as originally issued.